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LEARNING TO BE TOUGH

The government can secure its citizens only if it is serious about quelling crime

If India is to secure itself from terror, it must, first, unlearn the way it currently thinks about the issue. India's responses to terrorism and, indeed, even the country's capacity to respond, has been enormously inhibited by an absence of clarity, a partisan debate, tremendous confusion over the concept and, often, deliberate obfuscation. Current establishment assessments and understanding of terrorism are, consequently, riddled with internal contradictions that yield incongruous, wasteful and conflicting policy impulses. Only clear political perspectives and mandates can create the necessary foundations for the development of institutional mechanisms for the implementation of effective and coordinated counter-terrorism efforts, initiatives and policies. This, then, is the first imperative of an effective counter-terrorism response—to clearly define India's strategic orientation and posture with regard to terrorism, the basic counter-terrorism doctrine within which specific capacities are to be evolved and specific responses undertaken. Take away such a doctrinal context, and all initiatives will remain ad hoc, arbitrary and directionless.

There is, Carl von Clausewitz noted, no such thing as a strategy of permanent defence. While protecting assets and lives will remain a necessary and major part of internal security management, this cannot defeat terrorism. The Irish Republican Army encapsulated the terrorist's advantage in the adage, "You have to be lucky all the time. We have to be lucky just once". Effective counter-terrorism demands offensive capabilities. Terrorism can never be contained and defeated at its points of delivery. Its sources and its networks, wherever these exist—on Indian soil or abroad—must be targeted and destroyed.

Security is an indivisible. You cannot have an efficient

counter-terrorism and counter-insurgency response in a collapsing law and order and justice administration. The idea that we can 'target terrorism', even while we ignore other patterns of crime and threats to national security, is misconceived. There is no such thing as a 'small crime'. The same networks service both petty crime and major crime, including terrorism. The same compromised enforcement agencies 'look the other way' when this happens. The flaunting of verification procedures in the sale of a cellphone, for instance, may seem a petty infraction; but it has repeatedly facilitated major terrorist attacks. The untraceable cellphone has become an integral component for terrorist coordination and as a detonation device. Similarly, while there is much talk of the necessity of 'ending terrorist finance', the reality is that this can never be separated from other organised criminal financial operations, from the ugly underbelly of otherwise legitimate commercial activities, and from the flourishing black economy at large.

The overwhelming proportion of illegal financial operations are collusive—based on a continuing and symbiotic relationship of acquiescence between criminal enterprises on one hand and, on the other, government agencies and officials, as well as enterprises whose businesses lie within the ambit of the law. It is the vast black economy in India that provides the context of the movement of funds by terrorists as well. Hawala networks are not only used by terrorists, drug-traffickers, arms smugglers and other criminals, but also by corrupt businessmen, bureaucrats and politicians, as well as by numberless expatriate workers transferring money to their families home. Similarly, the smuggling of arms, ammunition and explosives cannot be brought to an end as

PRESCRIPTION

- All patterns of crime, however small, and threats to national security have to be tackled
- Operatives of illegal financial operations, including black economy, should be punished
- Our vast counter-terrorism experiences as well as successes can be put to use now